# Current Issues In Higher Education
# Student-led Discussion

## Education's Impact on Incarcerated Individuals in the U.S.

December 12, 2025

# Definition of Terms

Incarcerated - being held in jail or prison.

Incarcerated Students - individuals who are currently in prison and are enrolled in educational programs.

FIS - formerly incarcerated students

Recidivism -returning to crime or prison after release

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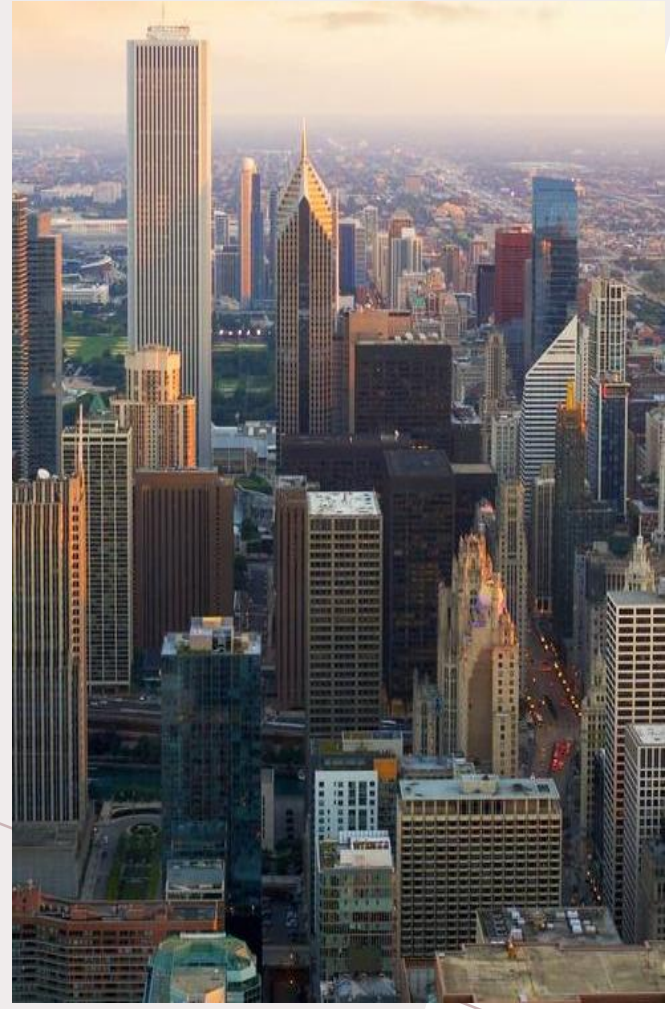
FAFSA – free application for federal student aid

Parole - release from prison under supervision.

Trauma-informed – an approach that understands and responds to the effects of trauma

# *Introduction*



- Colbert (2025): Formerly incarcerated students (FIS) and institutional support for degree completion.

- Only five percent of incarcerated individuals have access to postsecondary education, and an even smaller percentage complete a degree" (Escobar et al., 2013, p. 34)

  - Sokoloff and Schenck-Fontaine (2017) argue that "these staggering numbers alone suggest this population warrants critical consideration" (p. 96) and demonstrate a clear need for additional resources for FIP (Donaldson & Viera, 2021)

  - "collateral consequences" (Custer, 2018; Sokoloff & Schenck-Fontaine, 2017; U.S. Department of Education, 2016).

  - What are some of these barriers?

Barriers: Stigma, parole restrictions, and limited campus support
Support: mental health counseling, academic advising, tutoring, and admission support
Gender-specific support needs (childcare, career planning)
Policy context: second chance Pell, FAFSA reforms

**Phillips & Kwon (2022)**
Parenting classes enhance emotional healing, parenting confidence, and family relationships
Trauma-informed, structured programs are most effective

**Terry & Miller (2024)**
Literacy through experiential learning strengthens parent-child bonds.
The practical model served as a family-centered, preventive intervention.
for supporting incarcerated women before release

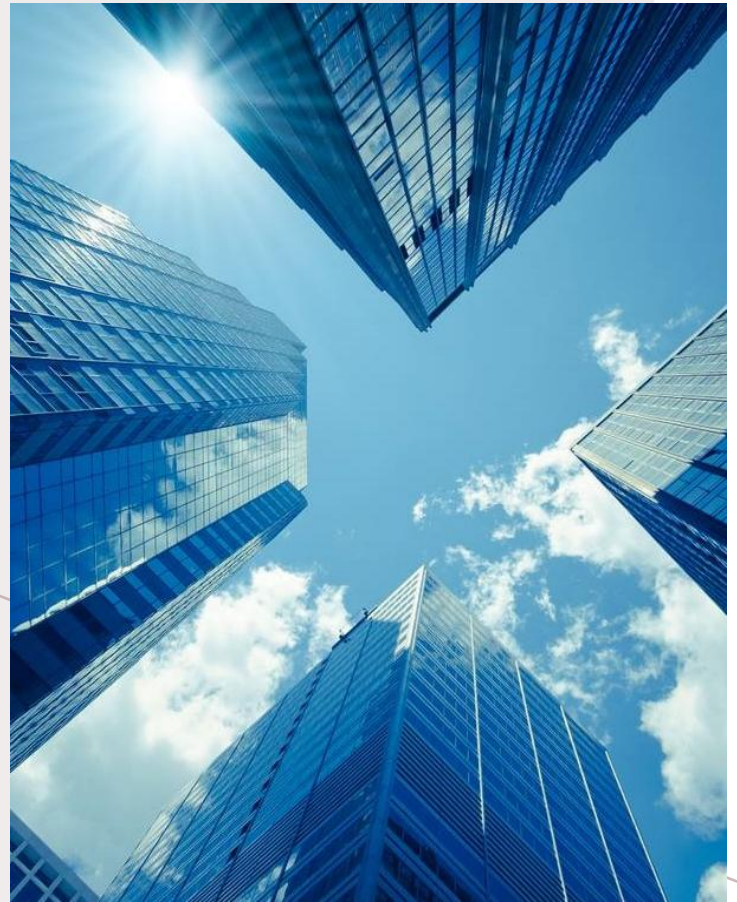
## *Discussion*

How can institutional supports influence the success of formerly incarcerated students differently from personal motivation?

Why are family-focused programs important for incarcerated women, and how might they complement academic supports?

What additional policy changes or reforms could have the most impact equity in higher education for FIS?

# *Practice And Policy Insights*



- Need for equity-centered supports at multiple stages: during incarceration, reentry, and higher education
- Intersection of academic, emotional, and family support
- Policy considerations for improving access and retention

# *Scenario*

- Each group acts as a university task force assigned to improve higher education access, retention, and success for formerly incarcerated students (FIS)
- Task
- Identify the top 3 barriers to student success (academic, social, family, or policy-based) – you may use readings as a guide
- Propose programmatic or policy interventions that address these barriers.
- Consider equity, scalability, and sustainability in their design.

# *Wrap-up, Takeaways & Reflection*

- Academic and psychosocial supports are critical for success
- Family-centered interventions enhance reintegration
- Policies like Second Chance Pell and FAFSA reform can reduce systemic barriers

What is one actionable takeaway you could implement or advocate for in supporting justice-impacted students?

*Thank You*